Gmail

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Stop Stirring

1 message

Beyond The Bend Yoga <laura@beyondthebendyoga.ca> Sun, Dec 7, 2025 at 10:00 AM
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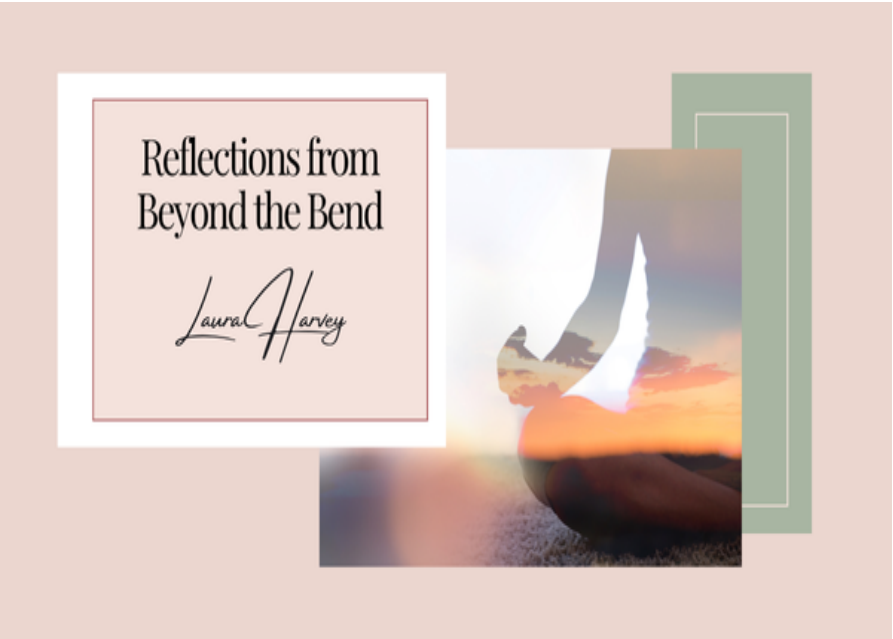
BEYOND THE BEND YOGA



Hello Laura

I've been catching myself lately in a familiar pattern. Something feels unclear - a decision, a feeling, a direction - and immediately, my mind begins its work. Analyzing. Sorting. Trying to think my way to clarity.

It's exhausting, really. All that stirring.

This week, an old teaching from Alan Watts kept surfacing, the one about muddy water. He said: "Muddy water is best cleared by leaving it alone."

Such simple wisdom. And yet so counter to everything we've been taught.

We live in a world that tells us clarity comes from effort, from doing more, figuring it out, pushing through. But what if the opposite is true? What if the very act of stirring is what keeps the water cloudy?

As we move into December and the energy around us begins to quicken, I've been wondering: What would it feel like to stop stirring? To trust that stillness might reveal what all our effort cannot?

This week's reflection is an invitation to explore that question together.

With warmth and gratitude,
Laura 💗

This Week's Wellness Wisdom

When Muddy Water Settles:
A Practice in Not Fixing

By Laura Harvey | Beyond the Bend Yoga

There's a teaching from philosopher Alan Watts that has stayed with me for years:

"Muddy water is best cleared by leaving it alone."

Imagine a glass of water, clouded with sediment. Our instinct is to stir it, to do something, to make it clear through action. But every movement of the spoon only swirls the particles back up, making the water murkier.

The only way for the water to become clear is to stop. To set the glass down and let gravity do what our effort cannot - allow everything to settle on its own.

This is such a profound metaphor for how many of us move through life, especially those of us in midlife.

The Habit of Stirring

Most of us weren't taught to leave things alone. We learned early that clarity, peace, and worthiness came through doing. Through trying harder. Through figuring it out.

When we feel anxious, we try to think our way to calm.
When we feel uncertain, we search for answers.
When something feels uncomfortable, we immediately try to fix it.

We stir and stir and stir, believing that if we just keep moving, keep analyzing, keep pushing, eventually the water will clear.

But it doesn't.

It just gets cloudier.

And beneath all that stirring is often a deeper fear: that if we stop, if we rest, if we simply let things be, something terrible might happen. We might fall behind. We might miss something important. We might discover that we're not okay.

But here's what I've come to understand through years of practice:

The muddy water isn't a problem to solve. It's a moment asking for stillness.

The Nervous System Connection

When our nervous system is in overdrive - juggling responsibilities, managing emotions, anticipating what's next - it's like constantly shaking that glass of water. The system stays activated, the thoughts keep swirling, and clarity remains just out of reach.

This is especially true for women in midlife. We've spent decades in motion - caring for others, building careers, holding families together. Our nervous systems learned long ago that staying busy meant staying safe. Stopping felt dangerous.

But now, in this season of life, our bodies are asking us to reconsider.

The fatigue we feel isn't laziness. The brain fog isn't failure. The emotional sensitivity isn't weakness.

It's our system saying: Please. Stop stirring.

This season of life isn't a punishment, it's an invitation. An Invitation to finally set the glass down. To let the sediment of decades settle. To discover what becomes visible when we stop trying so hard to see.

What Stillness Reveals

When we give ourselves permission to stop stirring, even for a few breaths, something subtle begins to shift.

The thoughts still come, but they lose some of their urgency.
The emotions still move through, but they don't demand immediate action.
The body softens, just slightly, as if remembering something it once knew.

This isn't about forcing calm or "doing stillness right." It's simply about creating the conditions for clarity to emerge on its own.

And often, what we discover in that settling is this:

We were never as unclear as we thought.
We were never as broken as we feared.
We were simply stirring too much to see what was already there.

The Invitation

As December unfolds and the pace around us quickens, what if we practiced something radically different?

What if, instead of trying to figure everything out, we simply let some things be?

What if we trusted that the answers we're seeking might arrive not through effort, but through rest?

What if we remembered that muddy water clears itself when we finally give it permission to settle?

You don't need to have it all figured out right now.
You don't need to stir harder.
You don't need to be clearer, calmer, or more together than you are.

You only need to set the glass down.

And breathe.

The water will clear on its own.

Practice of the Week:

Settling the Water

This week's practice is beautifully simple. You don't need props, preparation, or perfect conditions. Just a few quiet minutes and a willingness to let things be.

Find a comfortable seat. Let your body settle into the support beneath you.

Close your eyes or soften your gaze.

Take a slow breath in through your nose, feeling the coolness of the air as it enters.

Exhale gently through your mouth, as if you're releasing something you've been holding.

Now, imagine a glass of water in front of you. See the sediment swirling inside - cloudy, murky, unclear.

This glass represents your mind, your nervous system, your inner world in this moment. All the thoughts, worries, plans, and feelings stirring together.

Don't try to fix it. Don't try to clear it.

Simply watch it.

With each inhale, imagine yourself becoming still, like the hand that stops stirring.

With each exhale, imagine the particles beginning to settle - slowly, gradually, without force.

You don't need to make this happen. You're simply creating the condition for clarity to emerge on its own.

Continue breathing slowly for several minutes, watching the water in your mind's eye become just a little clearer with each breath.

Notice how your body feels.
Notice the space that opens when you stop trying so hard.

When you're ready, open your eyes.

Carry this image with you throughout your day: whenever you notice

Carry this image with you throughout your day. Whenever you notice yourself stirring—analyzing, fixing, pushing—gently remind yourself:

Muddy water clears itself.

All you need to do is stop stirring.

Important Reminder for Current Students

If you're currently in one of my classes and would like to continue in January, **Tonight (December 7th) is your deadline** to reserve your spot before registration opens to the public on Monday morning.

This gives you first opportunity to keep your place or switch to a different class time for the new session.

Simply reply to this email to let me know which class you'd like to join, and I'll reserve your spot.

Winter 2026 Session: January 12 – April 1

This winter, all four classes gather in one cozy location: **Rising Moon Studio** in Sherwood Park, where we'll practice by the fireplace as the snow falls outside.

In-Person Classes at Rising Moon Studio:

Evening Classes:

- **Mondays, 6:00–7:15 PM** – Somatic Vinyasa *(Mindful Movement & Embodied Flow)*
- **Tuesdays, 6:00–7:15 PM** – Restore & Reclaim *(Restorative Yoga for Nervous System Recovery)*

Morning Classes:

- **Tuesdays, 10:00–11:15 AM** – Rise & Restore *(Restorative Yoga for a Gentle Start)*
- **Wednesdays, 10:00–11:15 AM** – Morning Stillness *(Gentle Hatha for Mid-Week Balance)*

12-week session: $204 + GST ($17/class)
Drop-ins: $20/class (if space permits)

Maximum 13 students per class for intimate, personalized support.

NEW: Join Us from Home – Virtual Winter Session

For the first time, I'm offering **Livestream access** to all four classes for those who prefer to practice from home.

This isn't a recording. You'll be tuning in live with the studio class, breathing in rhythm with the group, held in the same container as the students in the room.

Virtual 12-week session: $168 + GST ($14/class)
Virtual drop-ins: $18/class

Flexibility built in: If you miss your regular in-person class, you can join any other class via Livestream that week, or drop into another in-person class if space allows. Online students can join any other Livestream class within the session. Life happens. Your practice can flex with you.

For full class descriptions, payment options, and registration details, visit:
👉 beyondthebendyoga.ca/classes

Registration opens to the public Monday, December 8.
Current students have until Sunday night to claim their spots first.

Coming Soon: Your Holiday Sanctuary

Before the holiday season fully arrives, I'll be sharing a small offering designed to help you hold space for yourself during the busiest weeks of the year.

Your Holiday Sanctuary will include three guided meditations to support your nervous system through December:

- Calming
- Permission to Pause
- Evening Self-Releasing

Keep an eye out for the announcement in next week's newsletter, or watch for a mid-week email with details.

A Closing Thought

In a season that asks so much of us, remember this:

You don't need to be clearer, calmer, or more figured out than you are right now.

You only need to give yourself permission to stop stirring.

The rest will settle on its own.

With warmth and gratitude,
Laura 💗

Our e-mail address is:
laura@beyondthebendyoga.ca

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